

Hazrat Ismail

Birth

When Ibraheem  returned out of Egypt he settled in Palestine, which was also called Can'aan. Up to that time he had been deprived of children. He continued to pray to Allah for offspring and Allah accepted his *Du'a*. It is so happened that his younger wife, Hazrat Hajira became pregnant. It is said that Hazrat Sara became jealous and envious of her and as result Hazrat Hajira was forced to leave from her company and presence.

According to the Torah she happened to pass by such a place where there was a well. There she spoke to some Angels and the well was called "the well of him who comes, looking alive." A short while later Hajira gave birth to a son and in response to the good news from the Angels his name was given 'Ismail.'

The Valley of No Vegetation

The story of the period after the birth of Ismail is mentioned in *Hadith* reported by Hazrat Abdullah bin Abbaas :

"Sayeduna Ibraheem , Hazrat Hajira and their infant son Ismail went forth and there

where the *Kabah* is situated today under a big tree, Ibraheem ﷺ left them there where the *Zam Zam* well is today. The whole area was empty and uninhabited at the time with not a drop of water in sight. Hence Ibraheem ﷺ left with them one water bag and a packet of dates. He then turned away from them and left. Hazrat Hajira followed him, and exclaimed: "O Ibrheem are you leaving us here where there is no other person, no companion, no friend?"

She kept on asking this but Ibraheem ﷺ kept walking away in silence. Then she asked: "Did your Lord command you to do this?"

Then he answered: "Yes. This is as Allah commands."

Hearing this Hazrat Hajira said: "If this is Allah's command then surely, He will not allow us to be destroyed."

Then she returned.

Ibraheem ﷺ kept on walking away and when he came to such a place where his family had disappeared from his sight, he turned in the direction of where the *Kabah* now stands and prayed:

"O our Lord I have made some of my offspring to settle in a valley without any cultivation, By they sacred House. In order O Lord that they may establish regular prayer. So fill the hearts of some among men with love towards them. And feed them with fruits so that they may give thanks."
(14:37)

For a couple of days Hazrat Hajira continued to drink the water from the water bag and ate some of the dates while

giving Ismail to drink of her milk. At last there was no more water and no dates. She became greatly worried and as she became hungry and thirsty she also had no milk to feed the child. The situation changed and the child too became besides itself with hunger. She left the child in one place and she then climbed onto a nearby hill-safa, hoping to see some person from there. But she could see no one. Then with the love for the child in her she came down to the valley and walked along till she came to the next hill-Marwa and again climbed onto it. When from there too she saw no one she came down and walked in the direction of the child. She did this walking around seven times. Reaching this point Rasulullah ﷺ said: "This is the *Sae'e* between Safa and Marwa." Which people perform during *Hajj*.

The last time she was on Marwa when a noise reached her. The voice started her as she was tried to see who it was calling her. She answered: "If you are able to help then come out and appear. I have heard you."

When she again looked she saw the Angel Jibrael ﷺ. The Angel struck its foot on the ground where the *Zamzam* well is today and water started to ooze out of the ground. When she saw this she built a sand wall around the water, but the water continued to flow out of the ground.

Rasulullah ﷺ said: "May Allah have mercy on the mother of Ismail. If she did not stop the water and if she did not build a wall around it, it would have been a very strong fountain today.

Hazrat Hajira drank of the water and gave Isamil milk to drink. The Angel told her:

"Do not be afraid or sad. Allah will not allow you or this child to be destroyed or to perish.

This place is the House of Allah and the building of it by this child and his father has been predestined by Allah. Allah will not destroy this family?"

After a while one of the tribes of Bani Jurhum came to settle near them. They saw some birds flying around and deduced that there was water in the vicinity. Therefore they also asked for permission to settle in that Valley. To this Hazrat Hajira replied:

"You have permission to settle here but on this condition that you will not be a part-owner of the water."

Bani Jurhum accepted this condition gladly and settled. Hazrat Hajira also desired that for mutual company these people should settle there. Hence they sent someone to call the rest of their tribe to come that way and built their houses. Ismail also lived among them and played with their children and so learned their language. When he grew up he married one of their daughters. Soon after Hazrat Hajira passed away.

(This report is found in Sahih Bukhari in two places: *Kitabul Ru'ya* and in *Kitabul Ambiya* and according to both reports Ismail ﷺ reached: "This Valley without any vegetation" as an infant child. It also states that Ibraheem ﷺ left his wife Hazrat Hajira and his child in this hostile desert, but he, being a Messenger of Allah, how could he forget his family there?

How could he be unmindful or negligent of their welfare? Again he used to come to this dry desert to visit them as seems clear from the last part of this *Hadith*.

The Ways of a Pious Wife

In that same *Hadith* there is a piece which describes Ismail's wives. Once Hazrat Ibraheem عليه السلام came on a visit to the house of Ismail عليه السلام, while Ismail عليه السلام was gone out somewhere else. He met the wife and she told him that Ismail عليه السلام was gone away in search of sustenance. When he next asked her what the situation was at home, she replied. When he next asked her what the situation was at home, she replied: "We are in great affliction and troubled. We are greatly in pain, difficulty and hardship."

Ibraheem عليه السلام then gave her a message to give to Ismail عليه السلام that he must change the thresh-hold of his door. When Ismail returned he found some '*Noor*' of prophethood in the house and inquired as to who had been there. Then the wife told him the story of the one who had arrived there and gave him the message. Upon this Ismail عليه السلام said that was his father who had come to visit and he informed her that the message was for him to divorce her as his wife. Thereafter Ismail عليه السلام married another wife and once again Ibraheem عليه السلام came there on a visit. Once again Ismail عليه السلام was not at home and again Ibraheem عليه السلام asked about what the situation was at home. This wife replied: "Allah be praised, we are well and our situation is good."

He asked: "What do you have to eat?"

She replied: "Meat."

He asked: "And what do you drink?"

She said: " Water."

Thereupon Ibraheem عليه السلام prayed: "May Allah bless you in your meat and water." As he left he told her: "Tell Ismail to keep his thresh-hold intact."

When Ismail ؑ returned his wife told him the whole story and on hearing it he said: "That was my father, Ibraheem ؑ and his message meant that I should retain you as my partner in life."

Circumcision

According to the Torah, when Ibraheem ؑ had reached the age of ninety-nine years and Isamil ؑ was thirteen years old Allah ordered him to perform circumcision. Before proceeding with the deed, Ibraheem ؑ first performed his own circumcision and then circumcised Isamil ؑ as well as all the males of his family and servants of the household.

This custom of circumcision is one of the salient features of the *Ibraheemi Religion* and has been ever since called the *Ibraheemi Sunnat*.

The Great Offering

Those who are near to the presence of Allah are made to walk through difficult paths. This is as was the case with Hazrat Ibraheem ؑ. The first stage of this path of obstacles was when he was cast into burning flames. At that time the amount of patience he showed and the resigned nature in which he accepted the verdict of Allah, was note worthy of his high stature. Secondly when he was ordered to leave his wife Hazrat Hajira and infant son in the uninhabited dry desert of Faraan. This too was no mean task. It now happened that for three nights successively Hazrat Ibraheem ؑ saw in a dream that Allah orders him to sacrifice his only son, Ismail ؑ in the path of Allah.

The dreams of the Prophets are 'true visions' and considered as being revelation from Allah. For this reason Ibraheem ؑ was immediately prepared to carry out this

command. But because the command did not only concern his own self but also included another person-his only son, he therefore told his son of the command and the dream. The son, being a son of such an eminent Prophet and reformer, immediately accepted the command and he answered:

"O father, if that is Allah's wish, then if Allah wills, you will find me patient."

Thereafter both father and son proceeded towards where they were to execute the sacrifice. They walked towards the wilderness. There the father, having acquired the permission of the son, bound his hands and feet just like is done with a sacrificial animal. He sharpened his knife and then turned Ismail with his forehead to the ground and began to slaughter him. Immediately Allah's revelation came to Ibraheem عليه السلام:

"O Ibraheem, you have already fulfilled the vision."

... This was indeed a test. Leave your son and offer instead this sheep by your side ... thus indeed do we reward those who do right."

When Ibraheem عليه السلام looked behind him he saw a ram sheep standing near the bush. He thanked Allah and sacrificed the ram.

This is that sacrifice and slaughter which Allah so approved of that He made it one of the main features of the Ibraheemi religion. And even today on the 10th of *Zil-Hijja* is being celebrated and commemorated all over the Islamic world.

However from this story it is not clear who of his children were supposed to be sacrificed, Ismail عليه السلام or Ishaaq عليه السلام. Although the Qur'ān does not mention the name of the

son, but according to the way the story is told, it seems without any doubt that Ismail ؑ is the one, studying the text of the Qur'ān. In fact that is the truth and reality. The story is told in *Surah Sauffaat* verses 100 to 113.

Erection of the Kabah

Although Hazrat Ibraheem ؑ resided in Palestine, he regularly came to visit Hajira and Ismail ؑ from time to time. Then at one time Allah commanded him to build the 'House of Allah.' He informed his son Ismail ؑ of the command and they started building the *Kabah*.

There is one report according to which the foundation of the *Kabah* was first erected by Hazrat Adam ؑ and the Angel showed Ibraheem ؑ where the original House stood, and where after thousands of years there was now not a sign left of the original House of Allah.

Through Revelation, he was shown where the *Kabah* should be built and with the help of Ismail ؑ they started digging the foundation and upon the original foundation the *Kabah* was erected. In the Qur'ān there is no mention of the previous erection.

It is a truth that before that time all over the world and in every corner of the world there were temples for the worship of idols and heavenly bodies, but this was the first House erected, solely for the worship of the One True God.

Couplet:

"Indeed the first House erected for the *Zikr* of Allah.

Is the one in Makkah, blessed and a fountain of guidance."

This house has the honour that an eminent Prophet like Ibraheem ؑ was its builder and another Prophet of Allah, the *Zabeeh*, Ismail ؑ was his assistant.

They built it and as the work carried on and Ibraheem (*Alaihis Salām*)'s hand could not longer reach a certain spot, Ismail ؑ provided him with a stone on which he stood. This stone used to move up and down as was required and today it is that relic which is known as the *Maqaam-e-Ibraheem*.

When the building was almost finished, and they reached that point where the *Hajar-e-Aswad* the Black Stone had to be fixed in place, Jibreel ؑ guided them further. He brought forth from the mountain the *Hajar-e-Aswad*, which originally is said to come from Paradise. This stone was fixed in the one corner.

When the *Kabah's* erection was complete, Allah said to Ibraheem ؑ:

"This house is a *Qiblah* for people of the *Ibraheemi Religion*. It is the direction for people to perform *Sujood* to Me. Thus it has been declared as the centre for the people of *Tauheed*."

There upon Ibraheem ؑ and Ismail ؑ prayed:

"O our Lord, make me one who establishes regular prayers and also (raise such) among my offspring. O our Lord accept my prayer.

"O our Lord make us and our offspring establish regular prayer and guide them towards *Zakah* and make them steadfast and grant them blessings in there fruits and sustenance and grant to all the inhabitants of

this world the guidance to look upon them with favour that they may come from far-off places to perform their *Hajj* rites and that they may gather at this center to acquire fruits for their ever lasting happiness.

The Holy Qur'ān has given Ibraheem ﷺ and Ismailes prayers at the time of their having completed the erection of the House of Allah, in which they prayed for the establishment of regular prayers, the performance of the *Hajj* (pilgrimage) and that the *Baitullah* may become the *Markaz* for *Tauheed*. These prayers has been mentioned in various styles in *Surah Al-e-Imraan* 3:97; *Surah Al-Baqarah* 2: 125-129; *Surah Hajj* 22:23, 33, 36 and 37.

Hazrat Ismail's Children

According to the Torah, Hazrat Ismail ﷺ had twelve sons who were called the twelve chiefs who in future were to become the fathers of tribes.

He also had one daughter called Bishaamah or Muhallah. Her sons were called the *Ashaabul Hijr*, the offspring of Na'bit. And the offspring of the son Kaydaar's offspring were called the *Ashaabir-Rus*.

Mention of Ismail (Alaihis Salām)'s in the Qur'ān

Hazrat Ismail ﷺ is mentioned in the Qur'ān on several occasions. In *Surah Maryam* he is mentioned by name and some beautiful qualities of his are mentioned:

"And mention in the Book the story of Ismail.
He was strictly true to what he promised. And
he was a Messenger and a Prophet." (19:54)

He used to enjoin on his people prayer and charity and he was most acceptable in the sight of his Lord. (19:54—55)

Death of Hazrat Ismail عليه السلام

When Hazrat Ismail عليه السلام was one hundred and thirty six years old he passed away. According to the Torah he died in Palestine and was buried there.

According to Arab Historians he and his mother Hajira passed away near the *Kabah* and were buried in the Haram near the Baitullah.

QASASUL AMBIYAA

STORIES OF THE PROPHETS

Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy (Rah.)



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Qasasul Ambiyaa

(Stories of the Prophets)

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ISBN: 81-7101-424-0

Edition: 2016

TP-471-16

Published by Mohammad Yunus for

IDARA IMPEX

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Qasasul Ambiyaa

The Holy Qur'ān does not relate historical facts merely for the sake of telling a story which is of historical value. Its main aim in relating happenings is to draw attention to the results, conclusions and deductions from these incidents so that they become a source of guidance for men and prove to be lessons for them that appeal to their minds and emotions that from these historical events, lessons should be derived. These lessons should convince them that the existence of Allah is an undeniable fact and that His Mighty Hand is playing a major role in the affairs of men. It should also bring to their notice that to follow the stipulations of His deen brings success and leads to salvation and is the way towards all progress. That is what Islām—the natural religion—is about.

From: Qasasul Qur'ān

Preface

The most authentic and comprehensive work of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy, *Qasasul Qur'ān* needs no introduction. However, the Manner in which our friend Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version of a voluminous and bulky work he has undoubtedly, fulfilled one of the needs of this time. He has adopted such a method of abridgement whereby not only has he retained and mentioned every important fact in the lives of the Holy Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) and other saintly personalities, which are of lessons to men, but also discussed in brought outline some other important matters. It is hoped that with Allah's grace, those persons who are occupied and busy at all times, will be able to derive adequate benefit from this work.

The great effort of Sayed Tanzeem Hussain in this old age of his is really something praiseworthy. May Allah reward him well for this great effort.

Qari Sayed Rasheedul-Hasan Hussainy Nadwi

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Jama Masjid, New Town

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P5 Muharram, 1308 Hijri

Publisher's Foreword

The respected personality of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy is one of the most eminent Ulama of the Indo-Pak Sub-Continent. His most approved and well-known book, *Qasasul-Qur'ān* is considered to be a unique publication on this subject. The point that distinguishes it from other similar books is the fact that after every story, Maulana has made use of deep thought and reflection to present to the readers the lessons and points of guidance from the related episodes. Thus for the teachers and lecturers at *Deeni Madressas* and for preachers in mosques and students of deen the study and perusal of this book is of utmost benefit.

The original book appeared in four volumes with over 1800 pages of subject matter. Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version there of in only 600 pages and this has been met with a verdict of approval from all academic circles, especially by virtue of the fact that he has fulfilled one of the most pressing needs of the time and by leaving aside unimportant discussions have given the busy and occupied ones also a chance to benefit from these work. May Allah reward him well.

Author's Foreword

All praise be to Allah who has guided us with the Holy Book and revealed to us the Qur'ān in a clear Arabic language and in it. He related the best of stories as an admonition and a reminder for the believers. And May peace and blessings be upon the Most truthful and trustworthy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, the messenger of Allah and seal of all the Prophets and upon his offspring, and companions who were all of them guiding stars for all the righteous ones.

Among the inimitable ways in which Allah has chosen for the sake of the guidance of men, is this that attention is drawn to the good and bad deeds of nations and the resultant fruits of such deeds of which they are reminded so that those deeds may be a lesson for men. For this reason those stories are not being related in a style as is generally done in history. The major aim is to convey the truth and to invite to Allah and with this in mind attention is only drawn to those aspects which furthers this objective. For this reason there is constant repetition so that these events can sink into the hearts and minds of listeners and they become attentive towards them. This sinking in and attentiveness can only be achieved if the same event is repeated in various ways and styles whereby sleeping faculties are woken up.

The Qur'ānic stories and events deal mostly with previous nations and the Messengers of Allah (*Alaihimus*

Salām) who were sent to them and bit by bit other matters also become included there-in, mostly dealing with the arguments over good and bad and the battles between the friends of Allah and the friends of *Shaitan*, which in itself proves to be a great lesson and admonishment for me.

But, leaving others aside, there are today so few Muslims who derive benefit from Allah's last and perfect law-book, the Qur'ān, to fill our hearts with *Iman* and *Yaqeen*. After all it is Allah's law and we are commanded to implement its orders in our lives, Moreover we are required to ponder over its meanings as this Qur'ān is the means forwards acquiring success and salvation in both this world and the here after.

At the time of the Revelation of the Qur'ān, the Messenger of Allah became so distressed and defected at the enmity and opposition of the polytheists that he raised this complaint to Allah:

(5:25—30)

However, in this 15th century, if we should examine our hearts, we will find that in spite of our claims to be Muslims and believing the Qur'ān to be the word of Allah, how few are who have made this word of Allah the pattern for their lives and the model on which to base their lives, who read and recited with this aim in mind?

It was my aim, seeing this condition of my people and myself, to translate this great source of admonition into Urdu so that by presenting the translated version, the hearts of people will automatically become drawn to the original i.e., the Qur'ān and thereby acquire everlasting happiness.

In spite of my simple style of writing, care has been taken to confine myself to a few special points.

- (a) In this book the basis for all the stories is the Holy Qur'ān and the authentic *Hadith* and these have been further elucidated with historical facts.
- (b) Where there appears any contradiction or differences in the stories as told in the old testament and the Qur'ān, then with clear arguments an effort has been made either to reconcile the versions or with clear arguments to prove the truth as is expounded in the Qur'ān.
- (c) An effort has been made to point out the nonsensical Israili stories and where there have been nonsensical objections from enemies, these have in the light of the true facts been made clear for what they are.
- (d) In some special places there have been introduced some discussions on matters of disputes in *Tafseer* and *Hadith* and after discussing these the views of the saintly elders have been mentioned as a solution.
- (e) The facts concerning every Prophet ﷺ and in which chapter of the Qur'ān they are mentioned, has been gathered in one place.
- (f) Lastly, together with all the above points, a special heading of "Results and lessons", is introduced, giving the actual objective of this book and its main purpose viz., admonition and warning. Special attention is drawn to this aspect.

Servant of the Millat

Muhammad Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy

22 Rajab, 1360 Hijri

Translator's Foreword

For me as the translator of this book by Maulana Hifzur Rahman is a great honour. Throughout my student days in Darul Uloom Deoband in India, Maulana Hifzur Rahman or as we know him then as the *Mujahid-e-Millat* was one of the most respected leaders of the Muslim community. We used to flock to listen to his most interesting lectures. And as the general secretary of the *Jamiatul-Ulama*, and a M.P. he was also a great 'Alim (scholar) as can be gauged from this book *Qasasul Ambiya* (Tales of the Prophets) which entailed great research. I can remember whenever the students were confronted with any problem in the lives of any of the prophets, they always took refuge in Maulana's book for answers. I took upon it as a great honour in being in some small manner associated with Maulana's scholarship, even though this is an abridged version of the original book. But I must also state that I found great difficulty in translating this book because of the exceptionally high quality of the Urdu language used in the book.

I hope that the English translation of Maulana Hifzur Rahman's scholarly work will also be of great benefit to the English-speaking people. I just hope that I have been able to do justice to the original thoughts of the author.

Yusuf Karaan
Strand, South Africa